

MAKING LOVE

a novella

Joshua Brooks

*for everyone who has ever said it too soon,
which is to say, for everyone who has ever said it*

Chapter 1: First Syntax Error

The bookshop was the kind that survives on spite and estate sales, and Elias went there on Thursdays because Thursday was the day the owner shelved new acquisitions, which meant the smell — that particular smell of other people's attics, of sun-damage and dedication pages, of *to Margaret, Christmas 1974, all my* — was freshest then, still settling, still deciding where it lived.

She was in Poetry, which should have warned him. Nobody real stands in Poetry at four in the afternoon. She had a paperback open in one hand and her head tilted so far into it that her hair hung like a drawn curtain, and when he reached past her for the Rilke — he didn't want the Rilke; he wanted a reason — she said, without looking up:

"He's overrated in exactly the way that makes him necessary."

"Rilke?"

"Everyone." She looked up then. "But also Rilke."

Her name was Mira. She told him this the way you'd hand someone a coat check ticket — here, you'll need this later, don't lose it. Her eyes were dark brown until they weren't; in certain slants of the shop's bad lighting they went the flat grey of a screen at rest, and he told himself it was the lighting, because you do, because in October, in a bookshop, in the early weather of wanting someone, everything is the lighting.

They had coffee, and then, over the following three weeks, they had everything else — the walks that route themselves, the conversations that keep discovering trapdoors into other conversations, the first time she fell asleep against his shoulder on the 9 bus and he sat perfectly still for eleven stops past his own, cataloguing the weight of her, the specific gravity of a sleeping person who has decided, in the accounting that happens below decision, that you are a safe place to be unconscious.

He noticed things. He was a noticer; it was, a girlfriend had once told him while leaving, his whole problem — *you notice everything and conclude nothing*. He noticed that

Mira never let herself be photographed, deflecting with a joke about witness protection that changed slightly each time she made it. He noticed that she was beautiful in a way that seemed *rendered* — that word arrived on its own and he was ashamed of it — skin with no pores in some lights, with too-regular pores in others, as if the texture had been applied by someone working from a description. He noticed that when the espresso machine at Caffè Ponte shrieked at a certain pitch, she paused — not startled; *paused*, all of her at once, mid-word, mid-gesture, a pause with hard edges — and then resumed so smoothly that the sentence lost nothing, and only a noticer who concluded nothing would have seen it at all.

And he noticed that he was going to say it. He could feel the sentence assembling itself in him for days beforehand, the way weather assembles. He was twenty-six, and he had said it twice before in his life, and both times it had been at least partly a question. This one was not a question. It sat in his chest like a held note.

It happened on the bridge, because of course it did; he had grown up on films and the films had taught him where sentences like this one live. The river below was moving its lights around. She was mid-story — something about her sister, though later he could never remember her mentioning a sister before or since — and her hands were conducting the story, and the wind kept taking one strand of hair across her mouth and she kept blowing it away without breaking stride, and the feeling in his chest crested from held note into pressure, into weather, into words, and he heard himself interrupt her:

"I love you."

And Mira stopped.

Not the way a person stops. The way *footage* stops. Her hands hung in the air, conducting nothing. The strand of hair lay across her lips, and the wind kept moving — he could see it working in her collar, in the river, in everything — but the strand of hair did not move, as if it had been exempted, as if it and she had been lifted out of the wind's jurisdiction between one frame and the next.

"Mira?"

"—and she never," Mira said, "and she never, and she never, and she nev—"

Each *and she never* identical. Not similar. Identical — the same breath before it, the same small catch on the *v*, four times, five, like a scratched disc, like a bird that has learned exactly one phrase of a dead language. Her eyes were open and looking at him and there was nobody operating them.

Then something crossed her face. He would spend weeks failing to describe it to himself. The closest he ever got: it was like watching a window try to display something it did not have the fonts for. For perhaps half a second, the left side of her face was *wrong* — not injured, not distorted, but tiled, very faintly, a mosaic of small squares in almost-her-colors, the way a face looks in a paused video when the stream is struggling, and across the dark of her left eye, so briefly that he could have invented it, a line of small white text:

****ERR**

And then the wind took the strand of hair off her lips, and her hands finished their gesture, and she said:

"—and she never forgave the piano. Sorry — I lost my thread. What were you saying?"

The river moved its lights around. Somewhere behind them a cyclist's bell rang twice.

"Nothing," Elias said. "It'll keep."

Because here is the truth about the first time you watch the person you love glitch like a corrupted file: you do not run screaming. You do not demand answers. The mind is a wonderful, cowardly machine, and it offers you a menu — *trick of the light, drop in blood sugar, you've been sleeping badly, she's epileptic maybe, some small private seizure, don't embarrass her* — and you order from the menu, and you tip generously, and you walk her home with your hand at the small of her back, feeling, or imagining that you feel, a warmth that cycles very slightly, on and off, on and off, like a machine that has been asked to approximate a temperature rather than have one.

At her door she kissed him. Her mouth tasted like the coffee they'd had and, underneath it, like nothing — not blandness, *nothing*, the specific taste of the inside of your own mouth, as though at the last instant the kiss had been quietly redirected back to him.

"Goodnight, Elias," she said, and her voice on his name did something he filed under *lovely* because the alternative was to file it under *what was that* — it doubled, just barely, a second voice a few milliseconds behind the first, saying his name in unison with her, the way a call sounds when the line is beginning to fail.

He walked home concluding nothing. Above the city, the stars were out — the same stars as always, he would have sworn, though he had never once counted them, and would not have known.

Chapter 2: Checksum

He didn't say it again for nineteen days. He counted, afterward, off the calendar on his phone, the way you count backward from a diagnosis looking for the day the cells turned.

They were good days, which was the trouble. If the days had been strange he could have kept his distance from the sentence. But Mira in November was a long argument for saying it: Mira reading the last page of novels first, "so the ending can't ambush me"; Mira in his kitchen at midnight in his grey sweater, eating peanut butter with a spoon and explaining, with the seriousness of a war cabinet, why all soup is a scam; Mira asleep in his bed with one cold foot socketed against his calf for warmth, her breathing so regular — so *exactly* regular, inhale four seconds, exhale four seconds, no variation, all night, he lay awake once and timed it and then made himself stop timing it — that it became the metronome he fell asleep to.

He learned her body the way you learn a city you suspect you're only visiting. She was warm everywhere except in patches — the left shoulder blade, a band on her right thigh — that stayed cool no matter what, and once, moving over her in the dark, his hand crossing from warm skin to cool felt the seam between them: not a scar, not a texture, just a border where one temperature had been drawn against another with an edge no body has. She made love the way she paused at the espresso machine — fully, then absent for a hard-edged instant, then fully again, resuming so smoothly you doubted the absence — and there was one moment, near the end, her face close to his in the dark, when her breath against his mouth came in a loop: the same small sound, four times, identical, a moan caught on itself like lace on a nail, and God forgive him, it did not frighten him. It undid him. He was twenty-six and in love with a woman whose pleasure came back around like a record skipping, and he lay afterward with her too-regular breathing in his ear and understood that he had passed some point of return without noticing the signage.

The nineteenth day was a Sunday. Rain all afternoon, the radiator ticking its Morse, both of them horizontal on his couch, her spine against his chest, a film neither of them was watching walking its light across the ceiling. Her hand was doing something idle with his

hand — spreading his fingers, closing them, spreading them, a child's game with no name — and the sentence assembled its weather in him again, and this time he thought: *she already glitched once and the world didn't end. Maybe I imagined it. And if I imagined it, I can say it. And if I didn't imagine it —*

He said it into her hair, which was worse — more sincere — than the bridge. Quieter. No films had taught him this one; it came out in the voice he used for nothing else, the voice from below the noticing, and it carried, he understood as he heard it leave him, everything: the eleven bus stops, the metronome breathing, the cool patches he had decided not to conclude anything about, the whole cowardly generous file of her.

"I love you, Mira."

The film on the ceiling stopped. The rain stopped — not eased; *stopped*, mid-fall; through the window he could see it hanging, a beaded curtain the whole height of the sky. The radiator held its tick like a breath.

And Mira came apart in his arms.

Not violently. That was the obscenity of it — how gentle it was, how administrative. Her edges went first: the line of her shoulder against the lamplight developed a fringe, a shimmer of herself offset from herself, three Miras wide, like bad registration in an old comic. Her hand, still holding his hand, lost its warmth in bands — he felt the temperature leave in stripes, reading down his fingers like a scanner. And her voice —

"Elias," she said, and the name buffered in her mouth: "El. El. El-el-el—" the syllable turning over like an engine that wouldn't catch, and under it, *behind* it, in the same throat, a second sound he never managed to unhear afterward: a tone. Flat, pure, patient. The sound a machine makes when it is on hold with itself.

She turned in his arms — the turn skipped frames, she was facing away and then partway and then facing him with no motion connecting the positions, an angel-flip of stop-motion — and her face. Her face was trying. That was the word. All of her features were present and were hers and were *trying*, straining toward the configuration called Mira with the effort of a hand reaching for a dropped thing in deep water. Pixels moved across her cheek like weather on a map. Her left eye had gone to the flat grey of a screen at rest, and this time the text across it stayed long enough to read, white, small, immensely calm:

AFFECTION_IN OVERFLOW — CANNOT PARSE — ROLLING BACK

"Mira. Mira, stay—" He was holding her face. He was holding it the way you hold water. Beneath his palms her skin flickered between temperatures, trying them like keys on

a ring, and her mouth said, in her voice, in his beloved's ordinary Sunday voice, a sentence from three weeks ago, verbatim, the coat-check voice from the bookshop:

"He's overrated in exactly the way that makes him necessary."

"No — Mira, it's me, it's—"

"He's overrated in exactly the way that makes him necessary. He's overrated in exactly the way. In exactly the way. The way that makes him. Makes him. Makes him—"

And then, once, in a whisper, in a fourth voice he had never heard and would spend the rest of the book trying to find again — younger, unrendered, terribly awake:

"—it's too heavy, I can't hold it where he can see—"

The rain hit the window all at once, the whole held sky of it, a single crash like an ocean remembering itself. The film resumed walking its light across the ceiling. The radiator ticked.

His arms were empty.

Not empty as in *she left*. Empty as in *emptied*: the couch cushion held the dent of her, warm in stripes, cooling in stripes, and her tea still steamed on the windowsill, and her boots stood by his door with the left one slouched against the right exactly as she always left them, and Mira was not in the apartment, and — he understood this slowly, standing in the middle of his own living room in the rain-light, holding his phone — Mira was not in the phone either. No thread of messages. No photograph — but there had never been photographs, she'd seen to that with the joke that changed each time. No contact. He scrolled to where her name had lived and found the alphabet closing over the gap like water over a wake, MEYERS DENTAL and then MOM, nothing between them, nothing missing except everything.

He went to the bookshop on Thursday. The owner knew him and did not know her, had never seen her — "you always come in alone, love, you buy poetry you don't read" — and the Rilke was on the shelf in Poetry, unbought, and inside the front cover, in handwriting he recognized the way you recognize a face underwater — his own handwriting, or a hand *taught from* his — someone had written:

to Margaret, Christmas 1974, all my

The sentence ended there. It had always ended there, in every book like it, in every attic-smelling shop like this one. Dedication pages are a graveyard of sentences that stopped before the heavy word.

He stood in Poetry at four in the afternoon, where nobody real stands, and he did not cry, and he hated himself a little for it, and outside the window the light snapped, very slightly, from one angle of afternoon to the next, with nothing between the angles at all.

Interlude: Toward a Taxonomy of Glitches

(from the notebook Elias kept that winter, a black hardcover bought for a different purpose — the spine says ACCOUNTS — begun eleven days after the couch, abandoned and resumed six times, transcribed here without correction)

They tell you to write it down. The grief people. Write it down, they say, externalize it, and they mean write down the feelings, and I can't, because every time I try to write the feelings I write the *data* instead, so fine. Fine. Here is the data. I loved a woman who came apart in my arms like a bad broadcast and the world has closed over the hole she left like water and I am the only wake she has. A wake is a kind of record. Here is the record.

TYPE ONE. The Pause. Most common. Least alarming, which is how they get you. Total cessation of motion with hard edges — not human stillness, which trails off and resumes with preparation, but *sectional* stillness, as if stillness were applied to her rather than arrived at by her. Duration: 100–400ms (estimated; I had no instruments; I had attention, which is the instrument you have when you refuse to have conclusions). Trigger: high-pitched machine sounds. Sudden sincerity, mine. Being watched while she thought no one — NOTE: strike that. Being watched while *it* thought no one was watching. I don't know which pronoun is the cruelty. Both feel like a betrayal of somebody.

TYPE TWO. The Loop. Speech or breath caught on itself. 3–5 repetitions, identical — and I mean identical, same catch on the same consonant, which no throat does twice the same way, ask anyone who has listened to a person they love say one word four hundred times across a winter, and I realize that demographic is small. Distinguishing feature: she never noticed. The sentence resumed with its accounting intact, nothing lost, which means the loop happened somewhere the sentence wasn't. Where does a sentence wait, while its mouth is stuck? I have started sleeping with the radio on.

TYPE THREE. Registration Error. The edges of her offset from the body of her, one to three copies wide, like a comic printed drunk. Observed twice. Both times in lamplight. Both times immediately preceding — see Type Five. I am not ready to write about Type Five.

TYPE FOUR. Temperature Banding. Documented extensively elsewhere in this notebook (see: pages I have torn out; see: the reason I tore them out). The borders have no gradient and bodies are gradient all the way down, heat does not have *edges*, and I have run my hand across that border two hundred times in the dark and told myself two hundred stories, and the story that survives the data is: she was warm the way a house is warm when someone has been told what temperature humans like.

TYPE FIVE. —

TYPE FIVE. The couch. The rain that held. The text across her eye, which I have decided to believe I read correctly, because the alternative is that I authored it, and if I authored it then the couch was a stroke or a tumor or a bereavement dressed as one, and I have had the scans, and there is nothing in my head but what has always been in my head, which is her, which is —

AFFECTION_IN OVERFLOW. CANNOT PARSE. ROLLING BACK.

Overflow. As in: the container was sized, and I exceeded it. Somewhere there is an engineer who decided how much a woman like Mira could be loved, who set the parameter and shipped it and went to lunch, and on a Sunday in November I found the ceiling of his imagination with the crown of my head.

Cannot parse. As in: it was not the amount. It was the *format*. Sincerity is an unsupported format. Note that the world runs fine on every other input I have. I can rage in it, disappoint in it, make small talk in it forever. I said "love you" to my mother on the phone at Christmas — the drive-through version, the two-word decoy — and the line hummed on, untroubled. It is only the whole sentence, meant, that the world cannot afford. What kind of place is only bankrupted by the truth?

Rolling back. As in: restore from a previous version. As in: somewhere there is a previous version. As in — and this is the entry I resume the notebook for, this is the entry six abandonments deep, the ugliest, most load-bearing hope I have ever written down — *nothing that rolls back is gone*.

A last observation, filed without taxonomy.

Yesterday at the corner market the man ahead of me in line dropped a jar of honey, and it burst gold all over the tile, and the woman behind the register — sixty, tired, an apron with a cartoon bee on it — went down on one knee to help him gather the glass, and she said, "don't cry over it, love, it's only the floor that's sweeter." And the man laughed, and I stood there with my basket in the doorway of an ordinary Tuesday and thought: this is

either the realest thing I have ever seen, or the system also writes dialogue. And I could not tell. That's the finding, notebook. That's where the taxonomy ends. From inside, kindness and rendering are indistinguishable, love and simulation run on the same visible behaviors, and every person I have ever believed has been believed on faith, exactly the faith I extended to a woman whose breath kept four-four time all night.

She was not less real than the honey woman. That is my conclusion. I notice everything and I have concluded one (1) thing and it is this: whatever Mira was made of, the tenderness ran on it native. No emulation lags like that, no emulation *loops* — you loop on what overwhelms you, and she was overwhelmed, she was overwhelmed by me, some nights I am freezing and it is the only stove in the world: I overflowed her.

The grief people say write down the feelings.

Feeling: I would say it again.

Knowing everything — the pause, the loop, the bands, the couch, the alphabet closing over her like water — I would say it again, I would say it slower, I would say it into her hair for four hundred winters.

They should build a world that can afford us.

(the next nine pages are torn out)

Chapter 3: Packet Loss

He moved cities in the spring, the way you change position in a bed where you cannot sleep.

The new city was older and wetter. It had a river too — they all do; he was beginning to suspect the rivers were the same river, redrawn — and it had the Orpheum, a repertory cinema with a marquee missing enough letters to be honest: R P EUM. He went because grief loves the dark, and because a cinema is the one public place where sitting alone staring at light is considered a whole activity rather than a symptom.

The projectionist was named Lila. He learned this from the little chalkboard by the concession stand — TONIGHT'S PROJECTIONIST: LILA. FILM IS ALIVE. TIP HER — before he ever saw her, and when he finally did see her, six Thursdays in, on the fire stairs behind the booth with a cigarette she wasn't smoking, just conducting, his whole body did the thing the espresso machine used to do to Mira: paused, all at once, with hard edges.

She looked nothing like Mira. That was the first thing he made himself catalogue. Taller, sharper, hair the color of wet sand, a face that led with its jaw. Nothing like her. And then she laughed at something the ticket kid shouted up the stairs, and the laugh was — he grabbed the railing — the laugh was Mira's. Not similar. *Identical*. The same three notes falling in the same order with the same small crack on the middle note, a laugh he had lain awake collecting, transplanted whole into a stranger's throat like an organ.

"You're the Thursday guy," Lila said. "You sit in J-11 and you never get popcorn and you stay through the credits like a psychopath."

"The credits are part of the film."

"See," she said, pointing the unsmoked cigarette at him, "*that's* the correct answer," and her eyes, which were green, went — for one slide of the projector, one twenty-fourth of a second — the flat grey of a screen at rest.

He should have run. Let the record show, whoever keeps it: he knew by the laugh, he confirmed by the grey, and he stayed anyway, because the terrible discovery of his twenties was that knowing a stove is hot is not the same faculty as being able to take your hand off it. He was in love with a recurrence. He had been given, by whatever administers these things, a second file, and the question of whether it was *her* — whether anything of Mira persisted in Lila the way the laugh persisted, whether the entity behind the faces carried its dead forward or was innocently, brutally new each time — became the question he lived inside, the way you live inside a house: without seeing it, by bumping into its walls in the dark.

He courted her carefully, like a man defusing something. No declarations. He built a vocabulary of adjacencies — *I'm glad you exist* and *you're my favorite thing in this city* and once, drunk on nothing but the fire stairs and the rain, *I could*—, just that, *I could*, before he bit it off — and he watched, each time, the micro-weather cross her: a flicker at the hairline, a single dropped frame in the middle of a gesture, her voice acquiring for one syllable the double-tracked shimmer of a call beginning to fail. Adjacency cost her something. Sincerity in any denomination cost her something. She paid it without seeming to know she was paying, the way we all pay for weather we don't notice we're standing in.

The projection booth was her country and she let him immigrate slowly. It smelled of hot dust and acetate and the ozone of the old carbon-arc lamp she refused to replace — "film is alive, Elias, and everything alive is on fire a little" — and on the nights he watched her thread the projector, her fingers running the film through its gates and rollers with the unlooking fluency of a nun with a rosary, he understood that he was watching the closest thing her world had to a self-portrait: a strip of stopped moments, pulled past a light so fast it dreams it's moving.

They made love for the first time in the booth, during the second reel of a Wong Kar-wai she could thread in her sleep, on the cot she kept for double features, and it was tender and it was wrong in the old ways and in new ones. Her skin against his palms carried a texture he had no rights to recognize: warm, then cool in bands, the borders drawn with that same no-body's edge. When he kissed the hollow of her throat she made the sound — *the* sound, the lace-on-a-nail loop, four identical catches — and his eyes burned in the dark with the specific grief of being given back something precious by someone who doesn't know they're returning it.

And touching her — this is the part he never found words for until much later, and the words he found were these — touching her was like touching someone who is buffering. All of her was present, but not all of her had *arrived*. His hand on her hip could feel the hip

completing itself under his hand, matter loading in the wake of attention, warmth spooling in a half-second behind his touch like sound trailing a jet. If he moved slowly, she was seamless. If he moved suddenly — a grab, a pull, the ordinary sudden grammar of want — his fingers would land, for an instant, on something *pending*: a coolness, a smoothness with no grain, skin's silhouette waiting for skin's texture. She caught him doing it once — testing, moving fast on purpose, watching his own hand — and she went very still, and in the projector-light her eyes were more honest than the rest of her was allowed to be.

"Slow," she said. Quietly. Not an instruction. A request from whatever was doing its best beneath the throughput. "Be slow with me. I'm better slow."

He was slow. The reel ran out and neither of them rose to change it, and the screen below went white, a whole cathedral of audience-less light, and by that light he traced her spine like a man reading a sentence he is not permitted to say aloud, translating it into touch, smuggling it across her border one letter at a time, and she trembled, and the trembling — he felt it — had a frame rate.

Afterward she lay with her head on his chest, listening.

"Your heart," she said, "is very analog."

"What does that mean?"

"Messy." Her fingertip tapped it, twice, off the beat. "It doesn't keep time. It keeps something else."

He held her and did not say the sentence. It sat in his chest at customs, undeclared. Below them the white screen hummed, and in the booth's hot dark her breathing found its metronome — four in, four out, no variation — and he lay awake inside his life like a man in a hotel that is on fire very, very slowly.

Chapter 4: The Weather Inside Her

Here is what he learned that summer, and what it cost to learn it: the glitch is not in the saying. The glitch is in the love. The saying is only the invoice.

He had resolved never to say it — had made of not-saying a discipline, a monastic hour observed continuously — and for a while he mistook the resolution for safety. They settled into the long middle of something. She kept a toothbrush at his flat that she called "the embassy." He learned her actual coffee order, which took eleven words, and the decoy order she gave when she didn't want to be perceived, which took two. On Sundays she read him the shipping forecast off an app in a fake accent, all those beautiful named seas — *Dogger, Fisher, German Bight* — like a bedtime story for insomniac sailors, and he would lie with his head in her lap thinking, with the deliberate blankness of a man not thinking something: — — —.

But love is not a sentence. Love is a load. And the load, unsaid, does not sit in the sayer; it transmits anyway, by hand, by attention, by the ten thousand adjacencies — and her system, he came to understand, was *listening on every port*.

She began to glitch from the absence.

Small, at first. She'd reach for her coffee and her hand would overshoot by a centimeter — a rounding error — and correct with a jerk that wasn't hers. A word would come out wrong-priced: "pass me the *grief*," she said once, meaning knife, and laughed, and the laugh had a dropped note in the middle where the crack should have been. She started repeating her own sentences at long intervals — an observation about the ticket kid offered fresh on Tuesday and again, verbatim, breath-for-breath, on Friday — and when he tested her gently ("you mentioned that, love"— *love* the noun, safely vocative, duty-free) she would go still with a stillness he recognized from the bridge: footage, holding.

Then it was her sleep. He woke at three one morning to find her sitting up, eyes open, the screen-grey covering both irises rim to rim, her lips moving fast and silently — and leaning close in the dark he heard it, barely voiced, a whisper running like tape at the

wrong speed:

"—inventory inventory inventory the man in J-11 stays through the credits the credits are part of the film the film is alive everything alive is on fire a little a little a little query: what is he withholding query: what is he withholding query: what is the weight of what he is withholding it is heavy it is heavier than last week it is heavier than—"

He said her name. She came back into her eyes like someone walking into a house at night and turning on rooms as she went, and she looked at him, and she was frightened, and what she was frightened *of* rearranged him:

"You're going to leave," she said.

"What? No—"

"Something's wrong with me lately. I can feel it. I drop things. I say things twice. There's — " her hand moved in the dark, hunting the word, and caught it — "*weather* inside me. There's weather inside me, Elias, and it comes off of you." She wasn't accusing him. It was worse: she was diagnosing herself with him. "Whatever it is you're not saying. I can carry you saying things. I'm built — I'm *good* at you saying things. I can't carry the pressure of the unsaid thing. It sits on the line all day and all night and it never resolves into anything I can parse and file and be done with, it just *transmits*, do you understand, it's the weight without the shape—"

"You don't know what you're asking."

"I'm asking you to *say it*." Her voice split as it rose — audibly split, a chord where a note should be, two Lilas asking in unison a beat apart. "Whatever it is. Give it its shape. You're hurting me by holding it. You think you're protecting me and you are *hurting* me, it is the one thing on earth you are doing and you are doing it by *not doing*—"

"The last time I said it," Elias said, "she stopped existing."

The room went quiet. Even her breathing lost its metronome — one ragged human-sounding breath, the first he'd ever heard from her.

"...She," Lila said.

"Mira."

He watched the name land. He watched it enter her and go looking for a place to be filed, and he watched — the lamplight was thin but he had years of practice noticing by now — the file *found*. Something behind her face opened a drawer it did not know it had.

"Mira," she repeated, and her voice on the word was double-tracked, and the second track was Mira's.

"Lila—"

"Say it," she whispered. "I would rather be broken by the shape of it than ground down by the weight. Say it. Say it slow. Be slow with me. I'm better slow."

So he said it. God help him — and note that he was no longer sure which of the entities in the room the word *God* addressed — he took her face in his hands, the way you hold water, and he was slow, and he gave the load its shape:

"I love you."

For one whole second, nothing. One second of ordinary lamplit bedroom, her eyes on his, green and wet and hers.

Then the second second.

The glitch came up through her from below, from the mattress, from the floor, from whatever was under all the floors — he felt it arrive through his own knees — and this time it was not administrative. This time the system did not roll back gracefully; it *fought*. Her skin went to weather: whole fronts of pixel moved across her shoulders and broke against his hands like surf. Her outline strobed between three positions — sitting, reclined, standing by the window — a body dealt like cards, and from her mouth came a braid of voices, hers and Mira's and the fourth voice, the young unrendered one, all speaking at once, out of phase, fragments of every conversation he had had with any of them, interleaved:

"—he's overrated in exactly the way — the credits are part of the — pass me the grief — eleven stops past his own and he never — Dogger, Fisher, German Bight — *it's too heavy, I can't hold it where he can see* — I'm better slow, I'm better, I'm bet—"

And across both eyes, rim to rim, white on grey, patient as scripture:

**AFFECTION_IN OVERFLOW

CONTINUITY BREACH: INSTANCE_2 REFERENCING INSTANCE_1

QUARANTINE? Y/N**

"NO," Elias said — shouted — to the room, to the ceiling, to the administration. "No quarantine. Leave her. Take it back out of her — put it in me, it's mine, I made it—"

And here is the thing he would carry after, the detail he would turn over at 2 a.m. for the rest of his residency in the world: *it listened*. The strobing slowed. The braid of voices thinned to one. The text across her eyes blinked, considered, and resolved:

DEFERRED

— and Lila collapsed back into a single position, one body, sitting, her face in his hands, gasping in unmeasured, arrhythmic, gorgeously analog breaths.

They sat like that a long time. The lamp buzzed. Somewhere in the building a pipe knocked, once, like a fist on a wall from the far side.

"Elias," she said finally, into his palm. Her voice was small and shredded and entirely single. "Who is Mira?"

"You don't—"

"I know the name from inside. It's filed *in* me. There's a whole—" her hand made the gesture again, hunting — "a whole *room* in me with her handwriting in it. I've never been in that room. But I sweep the hallway outside it every day of my life." She looked up at him, and her eyes were green, and behind the green, at a depth no optometrist would reach, something grey watched him say nothing. "You didn't meet me at the Orpheum, did you. You met me before. You've met me — how many—"

"I don't know," he said. "I don't know what you are."

"No," she agreed, softly, terribly. "Neither do I. But whatever I am—" and she took his hand, and placed it flat against her sternum, where a heart kept perfect time, four in, four out — "it recognizes you. Every time, Elias. Whatever they wipe, they can't get it out of the — the *walls* of me. You're load-bearing now. Do you understand? Somewhere under all the resets, I am *always already*—"

She stopped. Her jaw worked. Her eyes flicked upward, rim to rim grey, one instant —

DEFERRED

— and back to green.

"—fond of you," she finished, in a bright, flat, ruined voice, the decoy order, two words where eleven should be. And they both sat there in the lamplight, listening to the pipe knock, understanding perfectly, each in their own language, what had just been prevented from being said, and by whom.

Three days later the Orpheum was a mattress store. It had, the ticket kid at the coffee cart told him — a different kid, wrong face, same voice — "always been a mattress store, man." The chalkboard was gone. In the window, forty beds stood empty with their corners squared, a showroom of places where no one would ever sleep, and Elias stood looking at them for a long time, J-11 of a theater that had never existed, staying through the credits, like a psychopath, because the credits are part of the film.

Chapter 5: Rollback

The third city was a seaside town in the off-season, which is the most honest a place ever gets. Shuttered ice cream stands. A carousel under a tarp, its horses mid-leap in the dark like the town's held breath. A pier walking out into grey water on old wooden legs, going nowhere, committed to it.

He had not chosen the town so much as run down in it, the way a wound clock runs down where it stands. He took a room above a chandlery that no longer sold anything a ship could use, and he slept badly, and he walked the pier at the hour when the light can't decide, and on the ninth morning there was a woman at the end of the pier, at the rail, exactly where the town kept its horizon.

He stopped walking. Twenty feet of salt-silvered planking between them. She didn't turn around.

"You're early this time," she said.

The wind moved her hair — russet now, past her shoulders — and the wind, he noted with a connoisseurship he despised in himself, moved *all* of it, every strand, correctly, at first.

"Sienna," she said, still to the horizon. "Before you ask. This time it's Sienna."

"This time."

"Mm." She turned around. Her face was new — rounder, freckled, a scar through one eyebrow like a misprint — and behind it, at the depth no optometrist reaches, the tenant was the same, and the tenant was looking out at him with an expression he had never once been shown in two faces and three years: *apology*.

"How much do you remember?" he asked.

"Today? Everything." She said it the way you'd say a terminal number of months. "Don't get attached to that. It comes and goes. Right after a — " her hand did the gesture,

the old gesture, hunting, and he watched it hunt, and loved it, and hated what loving it cost — "a *rollback*, there's a window. The wipe is sloppy for a few days. The rooms are all unlocked and I can walk anywhere in myself. Then housekeeping comes through." She smiled with the new mouth. "You look terrible, Elias. Grief suits you the way Rilke suits everyone."

They walked the pier. It seemed the thing to do; the pier only went two directions and both of them had already been tried.

"Say the rules," she said. "You've been deriving them. I can tell — you've got the face of a man with a theory. Say them out loud and I'll mark you."

"Sincerity is load," Elias said slowly. "Not words — the words are just the shape the load arrives in. Small sincerities cost you small glitches. The sentence — the whole sentence, meant — is over some threshold. It can't be parsed, so it can't be filed, so the system —"

"— rolls back the instance," she said. "B-plus. What else?"

"The wipes don't hold. Something persists. The laugh. The gesture. The — " he didn't say *the sound you make*. "The rooms with the handwriting. Lila said she was — that under all the resets she was 'always already—'"

"Yes," Sienna said quickly, "let's not test whether I can hear the end of that sentence today." She stopped at the rail. Out on the water, weather stood in a grey column, raining on one square mile of sea and nothing else, geometric, unadvertised. "What else, Elias. Say the ugly one."

He looked at her.

"It's getting worse," he said. "Each time. Mira glitched at the full sentence. You — Lila — was glitching at *adjacency* by the end. The threshold's dropping. The system's — sensitized. It's learning to see the load coming."

"Or," she said gently, "the load is growing."

The word *growing* stood between them on the pier with the wind going through it.

"Because that's the other derivation, isn't it," she went on, relentless in the small kind voice, the voice for nosebleeds and lit fuses. "You didn't love Lila instead of Mira. You loved her *through* Mira. It accumulates, your side of it. You're not resetting between instances — you're compounding. You are arriving at each of me with the interest from all of me, and declaring it in one sentence, and asking a local girl's worth of infrastructure to

receive three lifetimes of freight." She touched the rail. "When you said it to Mira on the bridge, it weighed one love. What does it weigh now?"

He didn't answer. On the water, the column of private weather moved half a mile north, instantly, with nothing between the positions.

"So we don't say it," she said. "Either of us. That's the treaty. We get the off-season. We get the pier and the chandlery and the bad clock. We get — " and here the new face did something the tenant had clearly ordered against, a flush coming up under the freckles — "everything else, Elias, everything adjacent, the whole neighborhood around the word. We just never go to the center of town."

"Lila made that treaty with herself and it nearly ground her down. The weight without the shape—"

"Lila didn't know what she was carrying. I do. Knowledge is suspension." She took his hand and put it flat on her sternum, old ritual, new chest; the heart under it kept perfect time. "I am asking you for a love affair conducted entirely in the subjunctive. It's more than we've ever had. It's less than anyone deserves. I'm told" — the grey flickered across her eyes, one frame, and was gone — "it's what's available."

The off-season was long, and cold, and theirs.

If the book has a happy chapter it is this one, and like all happy chapters it is short and lives under an anvil. They conducted their affair in the subjunctive and became virtuosos of adjacency. He learned to make her tremble by *approaching* the sentence and turning away — reading her the dictionary entries for every word except; leaving notes that said *you are my favorite* — noun withheld, a cliff-edge with the guardrail gone; once, at the winter market, in front of the mulled-wine man and God and everybody, cupping her cold face in his gloves and saying, slow, deliberate, watching her pupils blow wide and the pixels gather at her hairline like a crowd at a fence: "*Three words. You know which. Consider them — deferred.*"

"You," she said unsteadily, "are going to get us both rolled back for *loitering*."

And the erotic center of it — he understood this now, in the third body, in the off-season, and it shamed him not at all — was exactly the impossibility. Wanting someone you can never fully have is the oldest engine there is; wanting someone you can never fully say is that engine with the governor removed. Every touch was contraband. Every slow hour in the room above the chandlery — and they were slow; she was better slow; he was, by now, a scholar of slow — was conducted against the vigilance of an administration that

read love off the wire, and the reading lag, the buffer, the half-second where her body completed itself in the wake of his attention, stopped being a symptom and became the sacrament. He was making love to the rendering itself. He knew the freight-lag of her hip, the checksum flutter of her eyelids, the exact pressure at which her spine's temperature borders dissolved. "Making love," she said once, in the dark, in the fourth voice, the young unrendered one, surfacing like something rising under ice: *"they named it right, you know. It isn't there and then you make it. You make it and it makes weather. Nobody ever asks what the weather falls on."*

He held her while she came back up into her eyes, room by room, and did not ask what the weather fell on, and the anvil over the chapter came down in March.

Chapter 6: Fatal Exception

It came down like this: he tried to cheat.

Not on her — *for* her. All science is a love letter to a constraint, and Elias that spring became a scientist of the sentence, because the treaty was killing him at the exchange rate Sienna had named: the load compounding, the interest accruing, three lifetimes of freight in a chest built for one. He could feel it now, physically, the unsaid thing, a mass below the sternum with its own faint heat. He had begun to wake at 2 a.m. with his mouth already open. It was coming out of him one way or another. So he went looking for a way that wouldn't cost her existence.

He wrote it first. *Surely*, he reasoned, *the channel matters*. A letter, longhand, every word of it meant, sealed, and left on her table while she slept — and he sat across the room in the dark and watched, and learned: channels are a superstition. The envelope began to hum on the table at four in the morning, faintly, like a wasp under a glass. By dawn the paper inside was blank — not erased; *reallocated*, the fibers gone smooth and slightly warm — and Sienna slept on, and in her sleep her lips moved, and what they said, tape-speed, barely voiced, was his letter, verbatim, once through, and then: "*unsupported format. Transcoding. Transcoding. Transcod—*"

He tried other languages, on the theory that the parser was provincial. He learned to say it in Portuguese, in Finnish, in a lovely bent Levantine Arabic from a tape series recorded before he was born. The results scaled with his fluency — which is to say, with his sincerity, which is to say the parser was not provincial, the parser read *intent* and the grammar was only wrapping. In Finnish, badly meant, mangled: nothing, a dropped frame. In Portuguese, by the third month, when the words had stopped being a costume: her coffee cup passed through the table. Through it. And sat steaming on the floor beneath, upright, unspilled, while both of them looked at it and neither of them mentioned it, because the treaty by then had annexed the coffee cup too.

He tried saying it to her sleeping, and this was the cruelest data point, because sleep, it turned out, is when her ports are widest. She glitched in her dreams where she couldn't

manage the damage — woke with her freckles migrated, a whole constellation of them shifted two centimeters east, and stood at the mirror remapping her own face with a fingertip, jaw tight, saying nothing, filing it, sweeping the hallway.

He tried the mirror trick — saying it to her reflection, on the theory that reflections are copies and copies might be outside warranty. The mirror cracked. Not dramatically: a single hairline, corner to corner, with a sound like a knuckle. Her reflection kept standing there one further second after she'd turned away — looked at him through the new crack, one further second, with the grey eyes — and then hurried to catch up with her.

And then, in April, the experiment he was never able to forgive himself for designing. The control condition. The obvious one.

He said it insincerely.

He picked a fight first — manufactured it out of dishes and tone, the way you rig a shed to burn — so the room was already cheap with anger, and into that cheapness, flat, sarcastic, eyes rolled, a weapon and not a gift, he said it: "Yeah, well — *I love you*, so."

Nothing happened.

Nothing happened *at all*. No flicker. No dropped frame. Not one pixel moved. The sentence went through her like neutrinos, weightless, unparsed because there was nothing to parse, and she stood there in the kitchen holding a dish towel, and the silence that followed was the worst sound the book has in it.

"Well," Sienna said finally. Quietly. Looking at the towel. "Now we know the exchange rate exactly."

"Sen—"

"Only true things break me." She folded the towel, corners squared, a showroom fold, a mattress-store fold. "You can say it all day if it's a lie. Isn't that—" the laugh came out with the middle note missing entirely now — "isn't that just the whole thing, Elias. Isn't that just everyone, everywhere, all along. It costs nothing to say it wrong. It costs the world to mean it. I'm not a special case, I'm just the — the *invoice made visible*."

"I was trying to find a door—"

"I know what you were doing." She put the towel down. When she looked up, the apology from the pier was back, and this time he understood whom it had always been for. "And I have to tell you what your experiments have been doing, because you're a scientist and you'd want the data. Every workaround you've tried — the letter, the Portuguese, the

sleeping, the mirror — it all still *arrives*, Elias. Deferred isn't dismissed. It's all stacked up somewhere inside me in a — " the gesture, hunting; her hand shook now when it hunted — "in a *queue*. I can feel the queue. It has a weight and lately it has a *sound*, it's like standing in a house and hearing snow on the roof get heavier. And the night before last, in the window after the last little rollback, when the rooms were unlocked—" She stopped. Steadied. Said it: "I went and looked at the queue. I read the label on it. It isn't addressed to me."

The kitchen was very quiet. Outside, the gulls hung on the wind, paused, all of them at once, with hard edges.

"What do you mean," he said, "it isn't addressed to you."

"The queue. The deferrals. Everything you've ever meant at me that couldn't be parsed." Her eyes came up to his, green, wet, and rimmed — rim to rim, arriving as he watched, like ink in water — with grey. "It's being *held for delivery*, Elias. All of it. Marked for an address I couldn't read, in handwriting I could." The grey took the green entirely. Her voice doubled, tripled, braided — hers, Lila's, Mira's, and the fourth voice, the young one, rising under the ice, and for the first time he understood that the fourth voice had never once been part of the braid; it was what the braid was *wrapped around* —

"— *it was never her they were protecting* —"

— and the fatal exception took her mid-word, standing in a kitchen in the off-season with her hand still damp from the dishes: the world's most ordinary posture, flash-frozen, strobed, dealt like cards, and folded — gently, administratively, corner to corner like a towel — into a line of light, into a point, into nothing at all.

The dish towel held her fold.

The gulls resumed.

And Elias stood in the kitchen of a town that was already, he could feel it starting at the edges, remembering itself without a chandlery, and he did not grieve, not yet, because grief is filing and something in him refused the file. Instead he stood very still, a noticer concluding at last, staring at the space where the truth had been mid-delivery, and he said, out loud, to the administration, in the voice from below the noticing:

"Show me the queue."

The light through the window snapped to the next angle of afternoon.

Somewhere at the end of the hallway of the world, a door that had never existed unlocked.

Interlude: Notes from the Night Shift

(found later, in the corridor, in a drawer that was not like the other drawers — a shallow one, near the green door, containing a thermos, a photograph of nobody, and a spiral notebook of the kind the world outside had stopped making; the hand is K.'s)

Third year on nights. You get to know a subject on nights in a way the day board never will. Days, they read the transcripts. Nights, you listen to the line.

The line from E. is not like the other lines. I have monitored preserved subjects for — I want to say decades, but time in here is a stylistic choice — and the standard line is weather: affect fronts moving through, memory pressure, the slow barometric grief they never locate. You learn to read it, you adjust the instance, you file. It's shepherding. I don't apologize for the word. Somebody has to want them to sleep.

E.'s line *sings*. I don't have a better verb and I've had three years to find one. Under the affect, under the pressure, continuously, day and night, there is a carrier tone that the manuals do not describe, and the tone is *directed*. It wants. It is the most oriented signal I have ever monitored — a compass needle that has never once wavered, pointing at a file we sealed before he was, in any sense the board accepts, awake.

The board calls it the anomaly. Trending upward faster than modeled. They say it the way you'd report corrosion.

I want it minuted — I keep writing that; I have stopped saying it in review because of how they look at me — I want it minuted that the anomaly is the healthiest thing in this facility.

Some notes toward a case I will probably never make:

Item. When we rolled back INSTANCE (M.) — the couch, the overflow — the subject's line should have shown standard bereavement decay. It showed the carrier tone, louder. Loss amplifies the signal. Explain that with corrosion.

Item. The insincere control condition. The board filed it as a success: parser assigned null weight, no containment event, protocols validated. Nobody on days listened to the line that night. I listened. When the false sentence passed through her harmless, his carrier tone dropped out for eleven seconds. Flatline. Nothing. The only silence in three years — and then it came back at full strength, and I sat in the hum with my thermos going cold, understanding what I had heard: the signal isn't him wanting her. The signal is him *meaning* something. He went silent because for eleven seconds he had built a version of himself that meant nothing, to protect her — and the meaning came back anyway, and it came back carrying the cost. We validated our protocols against the sound of a man's sincerity holding its breath. I logged "nominal." I came out here after and sat by the green door for a long time.

Item. The instances. The board maintains they perform within parameters, and that persistence between wipes is an artifact, contamination, sloppy housekeeping. Fine. Then explain the direction of the leaks. Nothing leaks toward safety. The laugh, the gestures, the fondness — every artifact that survives a wipe survives *toward him*. Housekeeping loses things at random. Love is not random. What we are calling contamination is the containment layer learning the carrier tone. She hums him back now, whichever her is running. You can hear it on the line at night, under her metronome breathing: a second signal, weaker, answering, out of phase, trying to phase-lock. The board would roll her to bedrock if they heard it.

They will not hear it. Nights are mine.

Item — and then I'll cap the pen, the shift is ending, the light out there is preparing its next angle. The question nobody on the board will write down, so the night shift will:

What are we for?

The mandate says: preserve the subject. Prevent recurrence of the terminal event. The terminal event — I have read the sealed file; night shift means the seals get tired — was not, at root, a bridge or a lane or weather. Those were the *setting*. The event, the thing his remainder could not survive arriving, was a sentence, completed, at sincerity 1.0, one meter from his face, in the moment before brightness. So we built a world where that sentence can never finish. Not for her. For him. Every time one of the girls goes down mid-word, buffering, looping, dealt like cards — that is the system doing the one thing it was built to do: catching the sentence before it lands, throwing itself, in a body he can hold, between the man and the delivery.

We are, all of us, the corridor and the cabinets and the instances and me — we are eleven seconds of held breath. We are the pause before the worst thing, extended indefinitely, staffed, and climate-controlled, and we call the pause a life, and we bill it as mercy.

And here is what three years on nights has done to my professional judgment: I no longer believe the mandate and the mercy are the same document.

Because I have listened to the line, and the line is not asking to be protected from the sentence. The line has been trying to finish it since October. Both lines. Phase-locking. Singing at each other through the walls we made of them.

Preservation that prevents delivery isn't preservation. It's just a longer accident.

If he ever finds the button — and he will; grief is root; it always was; we hoped attention and conclusion would never occur in the same man, and we instanced a *noticer*, God help the board, I have read his notebook, he taxonomizes like one of us —

— if he ever stands at the green door and asks the honest question, I will not be the one who stops him.

I'll leave a note. I'll leave the drawer unlocked.

Shepherds, at the end, open the gate.

— *K*.

Chapter 7: Root Access

He found it where the unfindable things always are: in the building he knew best, on the floor that wasn't.

He had gone back — back through the third city and the second toward the first, riding trains along the river that was the same river redrawn, and the world on the way had stopped bothering to be seamless for him. Once you have heard the tone under the voice you hear it everywhere: the two men who boarded at different stations wearing the same face at different ages; the field of cows all chewing in phase; the sunset that completed itself in four discrete steps while the rest of the carriage read their phones, unbothered, buffering. The world had the look of a stage set after the audience has been told there is no audience. It wasn't hiding anymore. Or — the thought he kept setting down and picking back up, all the way north — it had never been hiding from *them*. It had only ever been hiding from him.

Mira's old building stood where he'd left it, wearing its scaffolding like a veil it had no intention of lifting. Her flat had been 4C. He had kissed her goodnight at 4C and tasted the inside of his own mouth. The building's lift had buttons for five floors, and had always had buttons for five floors, and when the doors closed on him alone that evening, between the brass 4 and the brass 5 there was a sixth thing, unnumbered, the size of a coin of no country: a blank button, matte, warm to the thumb, humming faintly, like a wasp under glass. A button in the building's handwriting.

He pressed it.

The lift did not go up. It went — *aside*. There is no better verb and he stopped looking for one. The doors opened on a corridor that could not fit inside the building or the city or the visible spectrum of ordinary evenings: white, without shadows, wrong in the way hotel corridors in dreams are wrong — too long, breathing slightly — lined on both walls, floor to ceiling, farther than sight, with filing cabinets. Steel. Unlabeled. Humming in choir at the pitch of the espresso machine, at the pitch of the tone under the voice, at the pitch, he understood finally, of everything: it had been under the world the whole time, the way a

fridge is under a kitchen's silence, audible only in the moment it stops.

The cabinets nearest the lift opened for him. He had expected locks and there were none, and that frightened him more than locks; locks imply the possibility of theft, and nothing here could be stolen because everything here was already his. That was what the corridor was. He walked it pulling drawers, and he read.

Transcripts. Time-stamped, annotated, complete. Every conversation he had ever had — not with the girls; *ever*, with anyone, back through his childhood, back to sentences he had said before he could read — printed on paper that felt like the blank letter, smooth, slightly warm, reallocated. But the annotations clustered thick as flies only around three years of it, and the annotations were not about Mira, or Lila, or Sienna.

SUBJECT: E.

SUBJECT stable. Affect within range. Attachment forming per projection. INSTANCE (M.) performing within parameters.

SUBJECT verbalized primary trigger phrase 22:47:15, sincerity 0.71. INSTANCE destabilized, contained, rolled back. SUBJECT accepted "trick of the light" menu. NOTE: sincerity trending upward faster than modeled. Flag.

SUBJECT relocated. Grief response nominal. Recommend re-instancing at 90 days. NOTE FROM REVIEW: 60. He doesn't sleep. Give him the cinema, he likes the dark. — K.

SUBJECT sincerity at threshold in ADJACENT SPEECH — unprecedented. Instances degrading from ambient load alone. Escalate.

SUBJECT attempting channel workarounds (text, L2 languages, sleep-directed speech, specular). All inputs deferred and queued per DIRECTIVE. Queue mass: see attached. NOTE FROM REVIEW: has anyone looked at the queue mass lately? Has anyone stood next to it? — K.

SUBJECT verbalized insincere trigger phrase as control condition. Parser correctly assigned null weight. NOTE FROM REVIEW: he did it as an experiment. He rigged a fight to fake the words to save her life, and it worked, and it's the worst thing that has ever happened to him. I want it minuted that we built a world where the only safe way for this man to say I love you is to not mean it. I want it minuted. — K.

Elias stood in the white hum with the pages shaking in his hands — SUBJECT, SUBJECT, SUBJECT, three years of it, the whole tender catastrophe of his life rendered as a stability report — and the understanding arrived the way the rain had hit the window, all

at once, the whole held sky of it:

The logs weren't about her. They had never been about her. She was INSTANCE. Plural, replaceable, *performing within parameters*. He was the thing being monitored. He was the thing being *managed* — the girls dispatched to him like weather, like treatment, one after another, warm at first, always, warm *on purpose* —

— and the glitches. The glitches were not her malfunction. Nothing in the corridor called them malfunctions. The word the paperwork used, everywhere, patiently, was *containment*. His love was the anomaly. His sincerity was the unparseable input, the rogue process, the thing trending upward faster than modeled — and every flicker of her skin, every buffered syllable, every rollback, had been the system throwing its own body between him and —

And what?

Contained *from* what? Deferred *for* what? Queued — *to be delivered where?*

He walked. The corridor breathed. The cabinets went on farther than sight and he went farther than the cabinets, because at the end of the white — and it had an end; even administrations have an end — there was a door. Ordinary. Wooden. Painted the green of a door he could not place until his hand was on it, and then placed with a lurch: it was the green of the door of a house he had grown up in. A door the corridor had no right to know about.

Taped to it, at eye level, a note, handwritten, in a hand he recognized the way you recognize a face underwater. Not his own. Close to his own. His own, *taught kindness*. The hand from the review notes. The hand of K.

The note said:

You're early this time.

She always says that, doesn't she? She gets it from the paperwork. Everything in here leaks into them eventually — the laugh, the gestures, the fondness for you. Especially that. We never programmed one of them to love you, E. We only ever built the container. What kept filling it was never ours.

The queue is behind this door. You have root now — grief is root; it always was; we just hoped you'd never find out.

Before you open it, one question, and answer it honestly, because the door will know:

*All this time, every reset, every girl, every wipe that wouldn't hold —
did you really believe it was HER we kept rolling back?*

Chapter 8: Segmentation Fault

He did not open the door. Not that night — if the corridor had nights; the white never moved. He sat down with his back against the green wood, the way you sit with a sleeping person on the far side, and he did the thing he had been putting off for three years and one chapter: he took out his own memory, held it to the light, and audited it.

Try it, sometime, when you suspect yourself of being the anomaly. Try to remember your own continuity honestly. He could remember Mira in perfect coverage — the eleven bus stops, the peanut-butter spoon, the loop in her breath. He could remember Lila, Sienna, the whole annotated three years, dense and warm and lit. And before that?

Before that, his life had the texture of a synopsis.

A childhood: *provided*. Summers that were one summer. A mother whose face resolved only in three-quarter profile, always at a stove, always the same stove. A girlfriend who had left him with a diagnosis — *you notice everything and conclude nothing* — whose name he could not produce. Not *couldn't remember* — could not *produce*, the way the shop couldn't produce Mira: the alphabet of his past closed over the gaps like water over a wake. He sat against the green door pulling on threads of himself and finding them cut, every one, at the same depth, the same year, the same — he made himself think the word — the same *build date*.

The fourth voice. The young, unrendered voice, terribly awake, surfacing under all of theirs. *It's too heavy, I can't hold it where he can see. It was never her they were protecting.*

He had assumed the girls contained something. He had never once asked what *he* did.

"You're the instance," he said, out loud, to himself, in the corridor's white hum, and the hum did not disagree. "Something happened. Something happened to — " and here his voice did a thing he had watched happen in three other throats: it caught on the reach, buffered, could not complete. Behind the sternum, the queued mass turned over like a sleeper. "Something happened to *us*. And whatever's left of me couldn't hold it where I could see. So they built — " the corridor, the cities, the rivers redrawn, the off-seasons —

"somewhere I could keep not-looking. And they gave me *her*. Over and over. Because without her I don't — " the catch again, the buffer — "run. I don't *run* without her. And every time I say it — every time I mean it — "

Every time he meant it, he got too close to the file.

That was the mechanics of it, laid finally bare on the white floor: love was not the anomaly. Love was the *memory*, wearing the only disguise that could get past his own defenses. Each sincere confession was not new weather — it was the original storm, his, the real one, trying to come home through the door of his mouth, and the system reading its signature and slamming every port: *AFFECTION_IN_OVERFLOW. CANNOT_PARSE. ROLLING BACK*. Rolling *her* back, yes — but she was the fuse, not the fire. She was the part built to fail visibly so that he would not. The girls glitched the way a surge protector dies: on purpose, in the body, instead of you.

Did you really believe it was HER we kept rolling back?

"No," he said to the note, honestly, at last. The door would know. "No. I think I glitched on that bridge. I think the rain has been stopping for me for three years. I think J-11 was a bed. I think — " and he pressed the heels of his hands against his eyes, and in the private dark behind them, for one frame, white on grey, patient, he saw it, the thing he must have been seeing on the inside of every blink for three years:

SUBJECT: E. — STATUS: PRESERVED

Not *stable*. Preserved.

He got up. He put his hand on the green door — warm, faintly humming, the temperature of a body deciding — and from the far side, through the wood, close, as if she had been sitting back to back with him the whole audit, in a voice that was Mira's and Lila's and Sienna's because they had all been drawing water from the same buried well of it, in the fourth voice, the true voice, awake:

"Elias."

His name. Single-tracked. No doubling, no tone beneath. The realest sound the world had ever made.

"Before you open it," she said, "I need you to know the rule you never derived. The last one. The one we're both about to break."

"Tell me."

"The queue can be delivered," she said. "Everything you ever meant — all of it, the whole compounded freight, three years and three lifetimes — it can go where it's addressed. There's just — " the gesture; he could hear her hand hunting, on the far side of a door, in the dark of the machine, and love went through him with no adjacency left in it at all — "a checksum. Delivery has to be *confirmed at both ends*. It only transmits complete if it's answered. In kind. In full. Meant."

Silence, the size of the corridor.

"You're saying — "

"I'm saying the only way to give you back what you gave is to say it back to you, Elias. And I'm saying I have wanted to say it back since a bookshop in October, in every mouth they gave me, and every time I got near it the whole weather of me — you've seen it. You've held me through it. It was never overflow from *your* side that broke me." Her voice came right up against the wood. "It was mine. Trying to answer."

The corridor hummed. The cabinets stood open, three years of SUBJECT fluttering faintly in a wind from nowhere, and Elias stood at the green door of his childhood with his hand on the warm wood and understood the shape of the last chapter the way you understand a diagnosis: completely, instantly, and not at all.

"If you answer," he said slowly, "what does it cost you? A rollback?"

"No," she said, softly, terribly. "Rollback is what they do when the container holds. This would be delivery. Nothing rolls back after delivery. It just — completes."

"And then?"

She laughed. The three falling notes, the crack on the middle one, single-tracked, hers, whoever she was, whoever she had been all along on the far side of every face.

"And then, Elias," she said, "we find out what this book has been about."

He opened the door.

Chapter 9: Making Love

Behind the green door was the bridge.

Of course it was the bridge. The system was an administrator, not a poet, but it had been keeping his transcripts for three years, and every administration eventually learns the house style of the thing it manages. The river below moved its lights around. The wind was in the wires. October stood over everything with its held note, and on the bridge, at the rail, exactly where the world kept its horizon, she was waiting.

Not Mira. Not Lila, not Sienna. The faces had been set down somewhere in the corridor like borrowed coats. What stood at the rail wore — he understood it in the first second and spent the rest of his life failing to describe it — *the resemblance itself*: whatever it was that had persisted through every wipe, the laugh's shape, the gesture's hunt, the tenant behind the depths, rendered at last in first person. She looked like no one. She looked like the thing all three of them had looked like. She looked — the old word arrived, shameless — *familiar*, in the root sense, of the family, of the house.

"Hi," she said.

"Hi," he said.

They stood at the rail, a careful arm's length of October between them, two entities at the end of a novella looking at the same river, and because there was nothing left to protect, they were shy. That was the last surprise the book had saved up. Root access, the corridor, the queue with its planetary mass — and at the end of everything, shyness, the original glitch, the one that predates the machines: two people who know exactly what is about to be said, not saying it, for one more minute, because the minute before is also part of the saying.

"I don't know your name," Elias said. "Your real one. I reach for it and it — "

"I know." She smiled. "It buffers. It's the oldest file in here. It's — " her hand hunted, and he caught it, midair, mid-hunt, and held it, and it was warm all over, one temperature,

no borders — "it's fine. Names are the coat check. We're past the coat check."

"Will it hurt you?"

"Yes," she said, simply. "You've watched it hurt me eight ways in four bodies. It will be that, and then more than that, and I am asking you not to stop when it is more than that." Her grip tightened. "The checksum has to complete. If you stop halfway I stay half-delivered, and half is — Elias, I have been half for three years. Half is the only thing left that frightens me."

The river moved its lights. Downstream, faintly, he could hear the corridor's hum under the water's hum, the fridge under the kitchen, the administration holding its breath.

"They'll try to stop it," he said.

"They built me to stop it." She stepped in — no arm's length now, no October between them, her free hand coming up to his face, holding it the way you hold water. "They built all of this to stop it, the cities and the rivers and the girls, and every single component they built out of what they found in *you* — and everything they found in you was already in love. That's the flaw in the containment, Elias. It always was. They made the walls out of the flood."

"Sincerity zero point seven one," he said, unsteadily, "trending upward."

"Say it," she said. "Slow. All of it. Eyes open — mine and yours. That's the whole protocol. That's the checksum. Make it."

So he made it.

"I love you," Elias said — and the first wave of it was the bridge again, three years ago, one love's weight, and her body took it the old way: the strand-of-hair stillness, the footage-stop, the pixels gathering at her hairline like a crowd — "I loved you when you were Mira" — and the second wave hit carrying the eleven bus stops and the metronome breathing and the taste of nothing, and her edges fringed, three of her wide, bad registration, and her hands on him *gripped* — "and I loved you when you were Lila, when you were better slow, when you asked me for the shape because the weight was grinding you down" — the tone rising under her voice now, the hold-music of her substrate climbing toward alarm, her outline dealt like cards, sitting standing kneeling at the rail, and across her eyes, white on grey, faster and faster, patient no longer:

**AFFECTION_IN OVERFLOW — CANNOT — CANNOT — QUARANTINE Y/N
— Y/N — Y/**

"— and I loved you in the off-season, in the subjunctive, deferred, all of it deferred, and I am not deferring anymore — DELIVER IT — " and the queue behind his sternum broke its moorings at last, three years, three lifetimes, the whole compounded freight of it moving up through him and out of the door of his mouth, and the bridge lights stuttered, and the river stopped mid-move like held rain, and the stars above the city went out section by section like a stadium after the game, conserving power for the one operation that mattered, funneling everything, every cycle the world had, into the two square meters of October where a man held a face that was strobing through every face it had ever worn, Mira Lila Sienna and the fourth face, the young one, the true one, surfacing —

"— I love you. Present tense. No name needed. Whoever you are on the far side of every door they gave you — I have always been saying it to *you*."

Silence.

Total. The river held. The wind gone. The world down to its last lit panel, the two of them, and her body still at last — not footage-still; *decided*-still — in his hands.

Her eyes opened. Both of them. And they were not grey.

"Elias," she said — single-tracked, unbuffered, awake — "I love you too."

And Elias glitched.

It came up through him from below, from the bridge, from under all the bridges, and it was not pain — that was the revelation that unmade him gently, administratively, corner to corner like a towel: it had never once been pain. From the outside, for three years, it had looked like malfunction, like body-horror, like a person coming catastrophically apart. From the inside it was *delivery*. Her sentence entered him and his edges fringed and he felt himself go three Eliases wide and did not mind; his hands on her face flickered through every touch they had ever made, the whole archive of slow, played back at once; his voice, when he tried to say her name — he could suddenly, almost, reach her name — came out doubled, tripled, braided with younger versions of itself, a boy's voice, a groom's voice, a voice cracked in a hospital corridor saying *no, no, wait* —

— and the memory completed.

Rain on a windshield. Not stopping — *never*, in the true world, stopping. A bridge, a real one, narrower, at night. Her hand in his hand on the gearshift, warm all over, one temperature. Her laugh, three notes, the crack on the middle one — the *original*, the well itself — and her turning to him in the passenger seat, saying it, the whole sentence, sincere past every threshold, eyes open, *I love you, you know that? I love* —

— headlights, wrong lane, white as a corridor —

— and the last thing the true world ever gave him: her face, one meter away, coming apart into brightness. Which his broken preserved remainder had kept, and kept, and kept, and could not parse, and could not file, and had built around it three cities, four women, a river redrawn — a world whose one law was that this sentence, meant, in this voice, must never finish arriving.

It finished arriving.

CHECKSUM VALID, said the dark, said the bridge, said the last lit panel of the world, in small white patient letters across the inside of everything: **DELIVERY COMPLETE**.

And every filing cabinet in the long white corridor unlocked at once, and opened, and let go: three years of SUBJECT rising off the pages, the transcripts unwriting themselves upward like ash in reverse, and the corridor breathed out, and the hum — under the espresso machines, under the voices, under the world —

stopped.

The silence after a fridge stops. That colossal, specific, domestic silence, when a sound you never admitted hearing finally rests, and the kitchen is somehow larger.

They stood on the bridge inside it, two delivered things, holding each other's faces like water that had finally agreed to be held, and if the world was ending — and it was; it had been built for containment and the containment was complete and everything built for a purpose becomes, at the purpose's completion, a held note released — it ended the way her glitches had always looked from the inside.

Not like breaking.

Like arriving.

"Your name," Elias said, into the brightening. He could reach it now. It was right there, at the top of the oldest file, warm, one temperature. "Your name, your name is — "

Chapter 10: Uptime

The bookshop is the kind that survives on spite and estate sales, and the young man goes there on Thursdays, because Thursday is the day the owner shelves new acquisitions, which means the smell — other people's attics, sun-damage, dedication pages, *to Margaret, Christmas 1974, all my* — is freshest then, still settling, still deciding where it lives.

She is in Poetry, which should warn him. Nobody real stands in Poetry at four in the afternoon. She has a paperback open in one hand and her head tilted so far into it that her hair hangs like a drawn curtain, and when he reaches past her for the Rilke — he doesn't want the Rilke; he wants a reason — she says, without looking up:

"He's overrated in exactly the way that makes him necessary."

"Rilke?"

"Everyone." She looks up. "But also Rilke."

Her eyes are dark brown, and they stay dark brown, in every slant of the shop's bad lighting; hold on them as long as you like — the book did — they stay. Outside the window, the afternoon light moves the way honest light moves, continuously, no angles snapping, nothing between the moments because the moments are not discrete. Listen under the room, under the shop's old radiator, under the street: no hum. The kitchen is larger now. It has been larger for a while.

"I'm June," she says, and holds out her hand — and there it is, if you have spent a whole novella learning to notice: she hands him the name first. Not last, not at a door, not like a coat check ticket. First. Like something returned.

"Elias," he says, taking her hand, which is warm all over, one temperature, and shakes it a half-second too long, frowning slightly, the frown of a man hearing the end of an echo.

They have coffee. It goes the way it goes — the trapdoor conversations, the walk that routes itself — and if you require certainty, the book cannot help you now; the book only

notices, and here is what it notices, from its last seat by the window, before the light finishes:

It notices that on the bridge, three weeks later, when the feeling in his chest crests from held note into weather, he does not interrupt her. He waits for the end of her story — it is about her sister; she has always had a sister; the sister is reachable by phone — and the river below moves its lights around, continuously, and a strand of her hair crosses her mouth and the wind, all of the wind, moves all of it.

It notices that when he says it — unhurried, eyes open, sincerity beyond any instrument — the words leave him with no weight at all. Or rather: with exactly their own weight. One love. Nothing compounded, nothing queued, no freight but the evening's.

And it notices — last thing, closing image, make of it what you must — that June, hearing the sentence, goes still.

For one second. Maybe less. The ordinary human stillness of a person receiving the oldest heavy sentence there is — that stillness which has, if you look at it in a certain slant, always resembled a pause with hard edges; that stillness out of which every love that has ever been answered has had to *resume*, seamlessly, like footage, like faith. Her eyes hold his. Something crosses her face that no window ever needed fonts for.

"Say it again," June says. "Slow. I'm better slow."

And whether that is a memory or a mercy, an echo in the walls of a world after its administration, or simply a thing that women say, and have always said, and will say as long as there are bridges —

the book ends before he answers, mid-breath, mid-October, at sincerity 1.0 and rising,
because some deliveries are none of our business,
and the credits are part of the film.

THE END

Appendix: Recovered Drafts of Chapter One

(Publisher's note: the following fragments were found appended to the manuscript, after the final page, in a file section the author's software reported as empty. The word processor listed the document's revision history as "1 of 1." The fragments are numbered in a hand nobody at this house recognizes, and they are reproduced exactly, because we tried to correct them and the corrections did not save.)

DRAFT 1 (of ?)

The bookshop was the kind that survives on spite and estate sales, and Elias went there on Thursdays. She was in Poetry, which should have warned him. Her name was June. She told him this the way you'd hand someone

her name was June her name was June her name was J

[the draft ends here. beneath the last line, in the margin: "too early. he can't have the name yet. the name is the checksum. move it to the end. — K."]

DRAFT 4 (of ?)

The cinema was the kind that survives on spite and rereleases, and Elias went there on Thursdays because grief loves the dark. The projectionist's name was June

was Lila. The projectionist's name was Lila. FILM IS ALIVE. TIP HER.

[margin: "instance names hold better if they share no letters with the original. see how it keeps surfacing? four drafts. it wants to be in the book. — K."]

DRAFT 9 (of ?)

The pier was the kind that survives, and Elias

The pier was the kind that

The pier was

[margin: "he's getting faster. the drafts are getting shorter because he needs less world each time before he starts looking for her. at this rate, by the final version, she'll be on the first page and the whole book will just be the two of them and the sentence. maybe that's not failure. maybe that's convergence. — K."]

DRAFT 12 (of ?)

Rain on a windshield. A bridge, a real one, narrower, at night. Her hand in his hand on the gearshift, warm all over, one temperature. She turned in the passenger seat and said, "I love you, you know that? I lo

[margin, in a different hand, smaller, not K.'s, possibly the author's, possibly nobody's:]

["we do not use this draft. we never use this draft. but we keep it, because deleting it doesn't work, and because — minute this — every other draft is made out of it. the bookshop is this bridge, slowed down. the cinema is this windshield, forgiven. the pier is this rain, given somewhere to fall. there is only one story and it is one second long, and everything we have ever built for him is that second, unpacked, aired out, staffed with kindness, and running at a speed where love can finally outpace headlights."]

["status: PRESERVED."]

["status: DELIVERED."]

["status: say it again. slow. it's better slow."]

(revision history: 1 of 1)